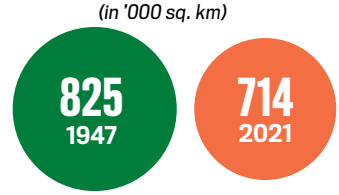


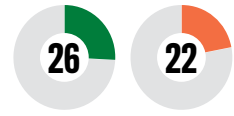


FOREST COVER IN INDIA

(in '000 sq. km)



% OF TOTAL LAND AREA



(Source: Richards and Flint. Assessment Year is in 1950; India State of Forest Report, 2021)

7,204 mn tonnes Total carbon stock in India's forests, an increase of 79.4 million tonnes compared to 2019



(approx.) India's share of the world's forest cover

10.4% of total forest cover under tiger reserves

India ranks **third** among countries to have reported net gain in forests in 2010-2020

Agriculture is the economic activity causing the greatest loss of forest land

45,000 Total plant species in India. The Botanical Survey of India (BSI) Plant Discoveries 2020 report mentions finding 267 new plant species in the country

MILESTONES

1952 Union government announces independent India's first **National Forest Policy**

1976 Forests elevated from state subject to one on **the concurrent list** via 42nd constitutional amendment

1980 **Forest Conservation Act** lays down procedure for putting forest land to non-forestry use

1985 Union **ministry of environment and forests** set up. Its earlier avatar was the department of environment, set up in 1980

2006 The **Scheduled Tribes & Other Forest Dwellers (recognition of forest rights) Act** is passed

The biggest pressure on India's forests has been its burgeoning population. Forests have borne the brunt of the need for firewood, food, highways and dams. The priorities of environment and development continue to be fought over as opposing ideals. The past few decades have seen the community management and preservation of forests being introduced through the 1988 National Forest Policy. At the time of Independence, around 25 per cent of India's area was under forest cover. As per the latest India State of the Forest Report 2021, that has shrunk to 21 per cent. All is not lost though, with an increase in coverage in the past decade, though it is still short of the forest policy goal of 33 per cent forest cover by 2030. Forests on private land, with an incentive to harvest them for economic gain, and zero tolerance towards deforestation in national parks and sanctuaries are the new headlines in the battle for India's woodlands. ■